1990s unleashed a nationalistic narrative, as Vajpayee's NDA navigated nuclear nuances amidst the Kargil conflict. We adapted adroitly, our tone in turn triumphant yet tempered, balancing gravitas with graphic grandeur to counter television's tempo.

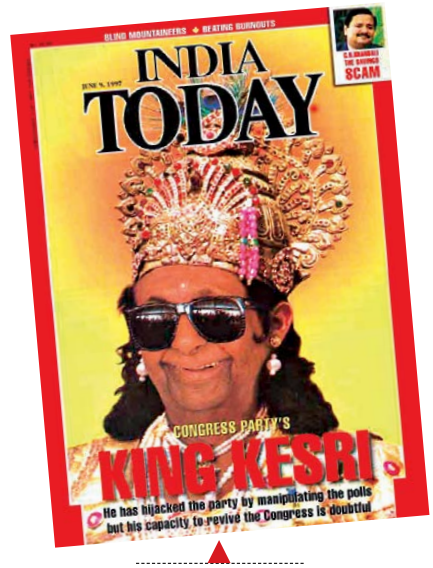
Our covers crackled with charisma—portraying personalities over ponderous policies, from Vajpayee's poetic prowess to Sonia Gandhi's enigmatic entry. Our reports on defence deals and diplomatic dramas anticipated events, as did our 1999 Kargil coverage which captured the national courage and foretold the NDA's electoral edge. We also didn't shy away from asking uncomfortable questions of the NDA government. Our cover stories, such as the September 2000 issue asking 'PM Vajpayee: How Fit is He?' amid health speculations that questioned his fitness to govern, put readers first by addressing national concerns head-on. Similarly, our exposés on telecom irregularities during the NDA era highlighted the gaps in policy and governance. In April 2001, 'The Importance of Being Brajesh Mishra' dissected the outsized influence of Vajpayee's principal secretary and national security advisor, revealing how one man's role shaped foreign policy and internal dynamics.

These stories exemplified our commitment to asking uncomfortable questions, echoing our legacy from Indira's time of ensuring the magazine put readers first. Amid this, the India Today Group pioneered platform synergy, launching Aaj Tak on December 31, 2000—a 24-hour Hindi news channel that catapulted our clout into crores of households. *Seedhi Baat*, which I hosted on Aaj Tak, debuted as a weekly war of words, grilling grandees with gritty queries. Entering the early 2000s, as Vajpayee's vision vied with 'India Shining' scepticism, we pivoted from power-centric to people-powered prose. Economic liberalisation had ripened urban upsurges, while consumer cravings redefined realities. We mirrored this, magnifying markets, medicines and lifestyles alongside politics. We also launched the Board of India Today Economists, assembling experts to elucidate on economic enigmas. It was the first forum to fuse fiscal foresight with journalistic rigour, decoding downturns and dividends for readers.

Similarly, our 'State of States' initiative, unveiled in 2003, revolutionised regional reckonings. It was a pioneering platform which measured metrics of politics and prosperity across states and spotlighted successes like Kerala's literacy leaps or Tamil Nadu's industrial impulses. 'Southern Focus' sharpened this: events in Chennai, Hyderabad and Kerala bridged the linguistic labyrinth, hosting dialogues on development and diversity via the language editions. It ended up amplifying state strengths such as Andhra's IT ascent or Kerala's social safeguards.

We also embraced the digital dawn early, integrating infographics and interactive insights. Our global gaze glittered with the launch of the India Today Conclave in 2002—'India Tomorrow'—which became a convention of the cosmic cognoscenti. Our first guest, former US vice-president Al Gore, galvanised the gatherings, discoursing on democracy and destiny alongside national luminaries, and elevating our brand from domestic doyen to global savant. The conclave connected continents, fostering forums on top-tier topics, expanding viewership and vitality. Yet, our indomitable impact lay in our investigative imprimatur, often orchestrating official overhauls. Anecdotes abound: our 2001 tie-up with *Tehelka* on defence corruption cascaded into Vajpayee's vigilance vows, while exposés on coalition corruptions contributed to the NDA's unexpected undoing in 2004.

Later, as the UPA ascended with Manmohan Singh as prime minister, we framed 'India Shining' versus rural realities, our rankings and reports reshaping reforms. Through this decade, what changed was our orbit—from elite echo to mass muse, from institutional introspection to aspirational articulation. What endured: unyielding integrity, insider insights, and our claim as India's conversational cornerstone. In the post-liberalisation labyrinth, we mastered the art of making sense of multifaceted mayhem. By 2005, we had evolved into an indomitable force, not merely reporting the past and the present, but also predicting the future, embodying the spirit of a resurgent India poised for global dominance. ■



Jun. 9, 1997

OUR FIRST COVER AS A WEEKLY FEATURED 'KING KESRI', THE THEN CONGRESS PRESIDENT SITARAM KESRI...A VIGNETTE OF VESTED INTERESTS AND VEILED AMBITIONS

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